

an ardent advocate of slavery, this was the final straw and it was time to act.

The plot that he and his co-conspirators hatched was multi-pronged. Booth took it upon himself to assassinate Lincoln. A 20-year-old Confederate veteran named Lewis Powell was assigned the task of killing Secretary of State William Seward, while 29-year-old George Atzerodt, the German-born owner of a Maryland carriage-repair business, was instructed to murder Vice President Andrew Johnson. The warped goal was to remove the Union's top leadership in one bloody night, thereby avenging the Confederate defeat and giving the South a chance to rally and gather new forces to continue the struggle.

The timing of the attack was settled when Booth heard that Lincoln was to attend a performance of a comedy, *Our American Cousin*, at Ford's Theatre in Washington on the Good Friday evening. Initially, the President's intention had been to take along General Ulysses S. Grant and his wife as guests of himself and the First Lady, but the general—no great lover of social occasions—had made an excuse and left town to visit relatives. In their place, Mary Todd Lincoln invited a friend of the family, Major Henry Rathbone, and his fiancée, Clara Harris.

The events of the evening

Booth knew the theater well, having performed there on many occasions. A familiar figure backstage, he had no trouble in gaining access to the building and wandering around its corridors at will. In the course of the day he took the precaution of drilling a small spy hole in the door of the presidential box, to provide him with a view of what was happening inside. That evening, he waited until the play was well underway before taking action. He knew the script himself, and had settled on one line as a cue for his deed—it always got a good reaction from the audience, and Booth hoped he could count on the laughter in the theater to help conceal the sound of the shot. Stealing into the presidential box with his pistol, he shot Lincoln in the head at the chosen moment, and then leaped down